Bersarinplatz in Friedrichshain – but always maintained they had been made homeless.12 (Pressed on this, she later admitted she could not accept the Bersarinplatz offer for ‘security reasons’.)13

After nearly a month in the infirmary, any last vestiges of hope that Erich Honecker would enjoy a peaceful retirement were dashed on 29 January. Minutes after being discharged, he was arrested outside East Berlin’s Charitie hospital and marched into ‘investigative custody’ at Rummelsburg remand centre, a former men’s prison. State prosecutor general, Hans-Jurgen Joseph, announced he would be tried for high treason. At Rummelsburg he was questioned, not once but several times. ‘This was not only shameful for my person but also for the GDR,’ Honecker later lamented. ‘I have to say I was very agitated and obviously could not have imagined anything like it.’ After thirty-six hours, the arrest warrant was annulled due to medical reports certifying him unfit for detention.

Homeless, and with their mental state worsening, Erich and Margot Honecker found shelter with the help of the Berlin-Brandenburg Evangelical Church. Pastor Uwe Holmer, leader of the Hoffnungstal Institute in Lobetal, Bernau bei Berlin, offered the couple a room in his rural homestead – an extraordinary gesture given his children had been refused university education due to their Christian faith. ‘The responsibility for the present situation of this country is everybody’s,’ the church said in a statement.14 ‘Some of the things being said today about the Honeckers leave the unavoidable impression that people are looking for scapegoats to make excuses for themselves.’15 ‘At Lobetal,’ Honecker reflected, ‘we spent most of our time out of doors because most of the entire world press was interested in us. The Holmer family made us very welcome for we had at first no means to cook for ourselves or anything else.’ Over the coming months, Margot and Erich not only breakfasted with the family, but also shared lunch and dinner. ‘From a Christian point of view, the Holmer family did not understand the whole thing either. That is the refusal of a dwelling and they thought it a Christian duty to take us in.’16 Recollecting the period, Holmer remembered Honecker was very disciplined, ‘although he was certainly angry inside. He soon realised, and so did I, that we had a different political outlook. Spiritually, too, we had no real bridge. So, we both avoided personal conversations’.17